Interpretation and Tone

Voicing, long phrases, pedal clarity, articulation and critical listening.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Project a melody inside a chord
2. Shape a long musical sentence
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7. Just As I Am: listening through pedal changes
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9. Abide with Me: lyrical piano

1. Project a melody inside a chord

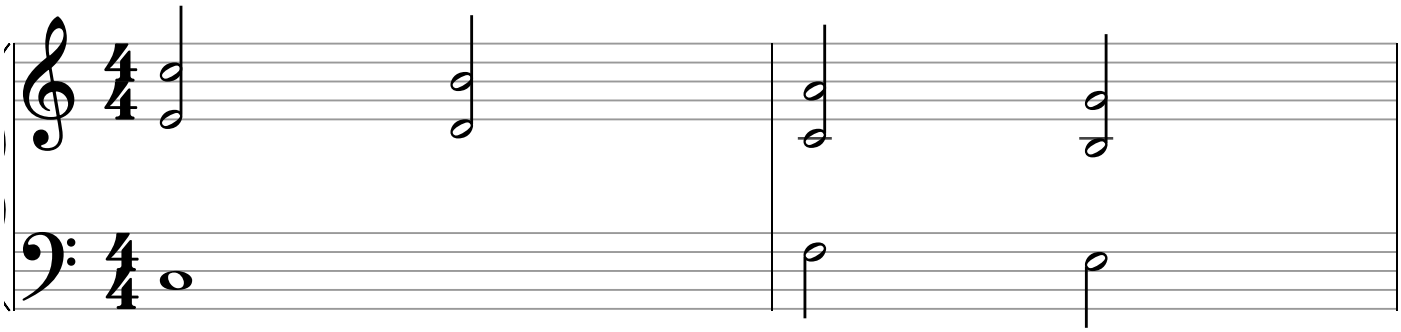
Give the upper voice direction without striking it harshly.

Project a melody inside a chord

Practise the top line alone and sing toward one destination. Restore the lower chord tones at a softer dynamic, then compare recordings. A clear melody does not require a hard attack; reduce the accompaniment first. Prepare each chord shape before moving, and keep the hand responsive rather than pressing into the keys after the sound has begun.

Practise · A singing top line

First play C-B-A-G-F-G-C alone. Then restore the lower tones softly.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Quiet middle, clear bass

Hear the outer lines while the inner chord remains light.

Practise independently

Record from the same position and volume twice. Choose the version in which a listener can follow the melody without having to search for it.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Shape a long musical sentence
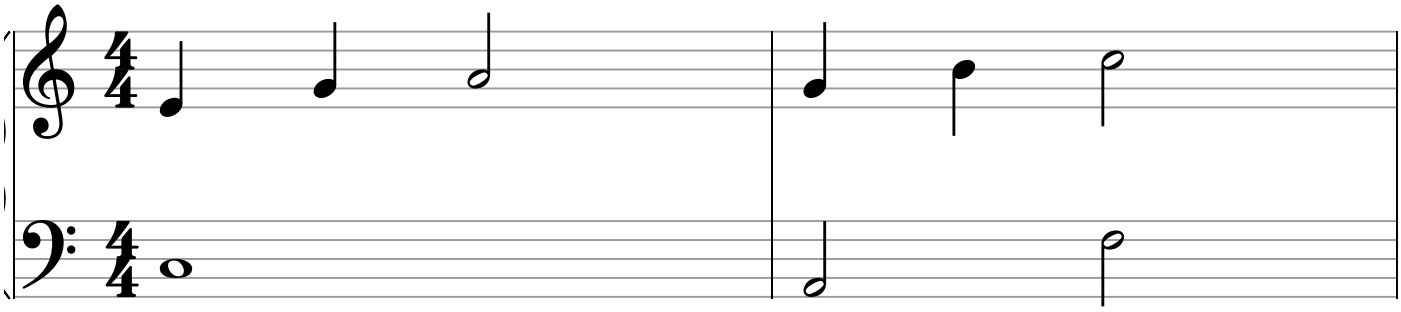
Connect local gestures to one larger destination.

Shape a long musical sentence

Mark the phrase beginning, high point and arrival. A short crescendo may belong inside a longer diminuendo; avoid treating every bar as a separate swell. Sing the line and notice where it needs a breath. Keep accompaniment intensity tied to the melodic destination instead of its finger difficulty.

Practise · One destination in four bars

Build gently toward D5 in bar 3, then settle into the ending.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · An answering phrase

Make this answer sound related to the first sentence.

Practise independently

Play both phrases without a demonstration. Mark one principal destination for each and explain how the ending sounds different from the middle.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Pedal for clarity and colour

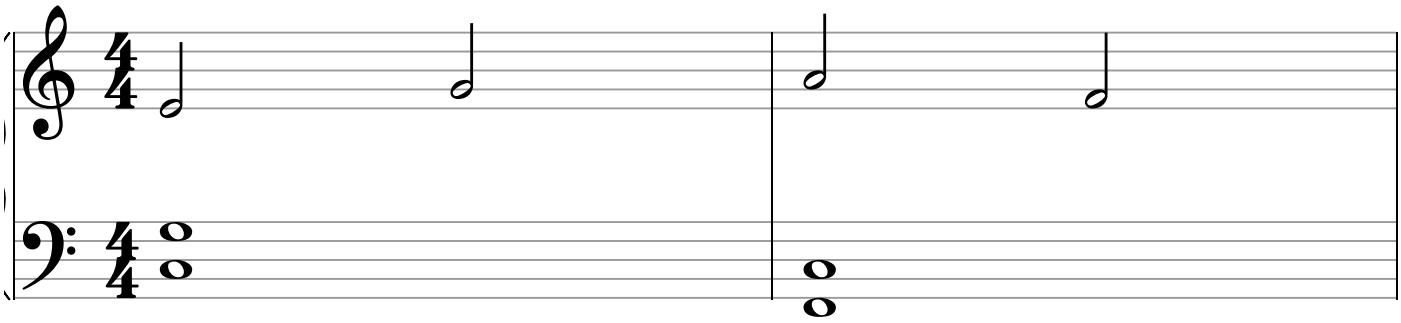
Listen to the instrument instead of relying on a fixed foot pattern.

Pedal for clarity and colour

Learn the notes without pedal. For a clean legato change, play the new harmony, lift the pedal enough to clear the old sound, then depress it again. The timing and depth depend on the piano and room. If your digital pedal supports only on/off, use short clear changes; half-pedal requires compatible continuous hardware. More pedal is not a substitute for connected fingering.

Practise · Change with the harmony

First play dry. Offline, add a pedal change after each new left-hand harmony.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Listen to moving bass notes

Keep this dry at first; avoid carrying all four bass notes into one blur.

Practise independently

Compare no pedal, frequent changes and longer pedal offline. Choose the clearest version that still supports the phrase. The app does not verify pedal position or acoustic clarity.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Choose articulation that fits the hymn
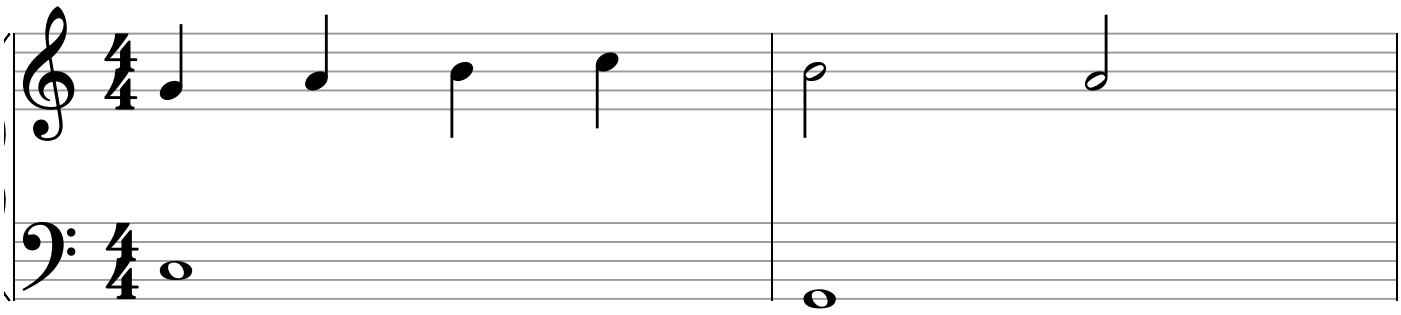
Separate a breath from an accidental break in the line.

Choose articulation that fits the hymn

A solemn chorale, a lilting hymn and a solo prelude need different touches. Choose where notes connect, where consonant-like releases clarify the rhythm, and where a phrase breath belongs. Practise the same line legato and gently detached offline. The written reference gives the pitches and rhythm; your release and tone choices supply the character.

Practise · Connected reference

Join the melody with the fingers before adding pedal.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Space for a breath

Keep the rests audible and arrive together after them.

Practise independently

Perform one phrase in two distinct characters and describe the releases you changed. Keep the same basic pulse so the contrast comes from articulation, not accidental rushing.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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5. Use a recording as a teacher
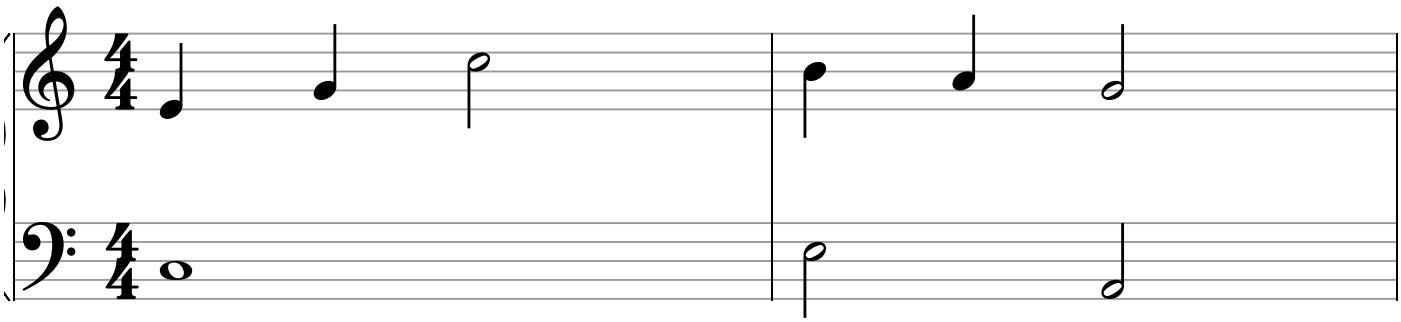
Compare an intended musical result with what is actually audible.

Use a recording as a teacher

Before recording, name one listening question: Is the tune clear? Are the pedal changes clean? Does the final cadence sound prepared? Make one uninterrupted take without correcting during playback. Listen once for the whole phrase and once for your question. Choose a single repair; do not turn the recording into a list of every imperfect note.

Practise · A short recorded take

If you have a recorder, capture this once. Keep going after a small slip.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A second take with one change

Try a quieter accompaniment, keeping the melodic pulse unchanged.

Practise independently

Keep a brief practice note: intended change, audible result, next step. A completed pitch check cannot answer your tone question; listening can.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Abide with Me: a long musical sentence

Sing the phrase before playing. Choose one destination, lighten supporting tones and let the cadence settle without losing the line.

Prepare the score

Sing the phrase before playing. Choose one destination, lighten supporting tones and let the cadence settle without losing the line.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Sing the phrase before playing. Choose one destination, lighten supporting tones and let the cadence settle without losing the line.

Practise · Abide with Me: a long musical sentence

Sing the phrase before playing. Choose one destination, lighten supporting tones and let the cadence settle without losing the line.

Make your own musical decision

Record a dry version and a pedalled version. Keep the one in which the phrase is connected and the harmony remains clear.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Just As I Am: listening through pedal changes

Learn this 6/4 setting without pedal. Add changes after new harmonies sound, listening for a clean bass and an unbroken tune.

Prepare the score
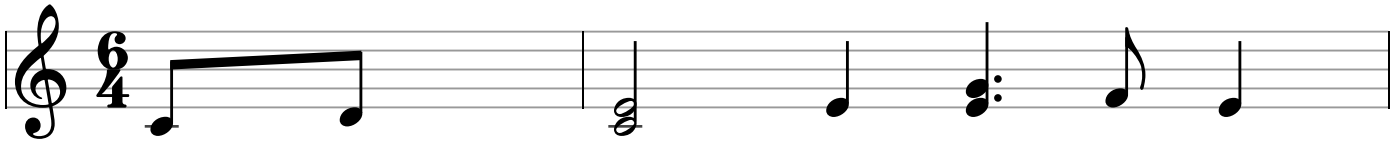
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Learn this 6/4 setting without pedal. Add changes after new harmonies sound, listening for a clean bass and an unbroken tune.

Practise · Just As I Am: listening through pedal changes

Learn this 6/4 setting without pedal. Add changes after new harmonies sound, listening for a clean bass and an unbroken tune.

Make your own musical decision

If your pedal supports continuous depth, compare shallow and deeper use offline. With an on/off pedal, prefer shorter clean changes.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. It Is Well with My Soul: lyrical piano

Sustain a clear melodic sentence, balance the paired right-hand notes and clear the pedal as the harmony changes. Let the ending sound prepared.

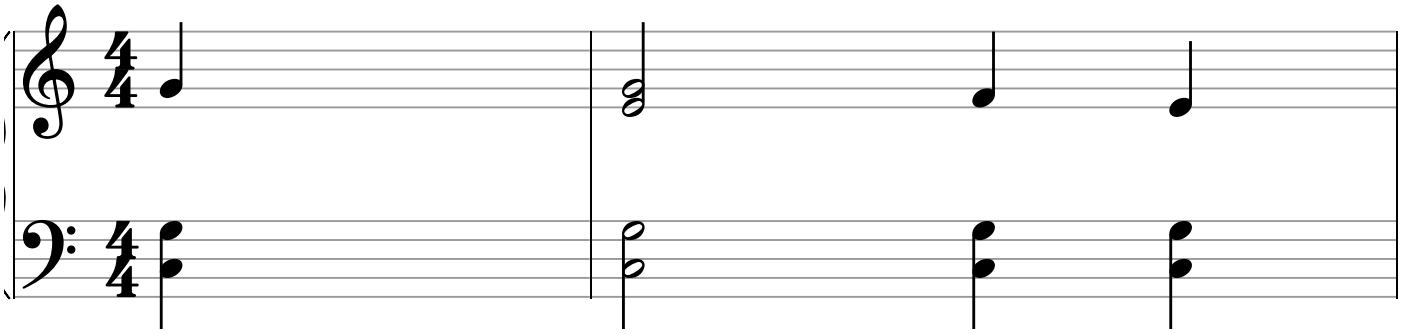
Prepare a complete performance

Sustain a clear melodic sentence, balance the paired right-hand notes and clear the pedal as the harmony changes. Let the ending sound prepared.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: It Is Well with My Soul

Sustain a clear melodic sentence, balance the paired right-hand notes and clear the pedal as the harmony changes. Let the ending sound prepared.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Sustain a clear melodic sentence, balance the paired right-hand notes and clear the pedal as the harmony changes. Let the ending sound prepared.

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9. Abide with Me: lyrical piano

Choose a long phrase destination, voice the melody above its supporting tones and listen for clean pedal changes and a prepared final release.

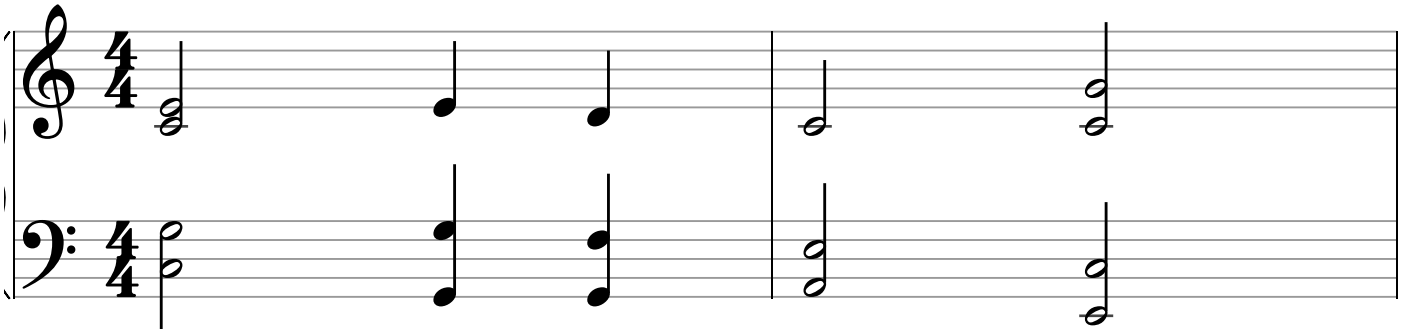
Prepare a complete performance

Choose a long phrase destination, voice the melody above its supporting tones and listen for clean pedal changes and a prepared final release.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Abide with Me

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Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Choose a long phrase destination, voice the melody above its supporting tones and listen for clean pedal changes and a prepared final release.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Give the upper voice direction without striking it harshly.
- ☐ Connect local gestures to one larger destination.
- ☐ Listen to the instrument instead of relying on a fixed foot pattern.
- ☐ Separate a breath from an accidental break in the line.
- ☐ Compare an intended musical result with what is actually audible.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, clear voicing, reliable pulse, comfortable movement and a deliberate ending.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
